

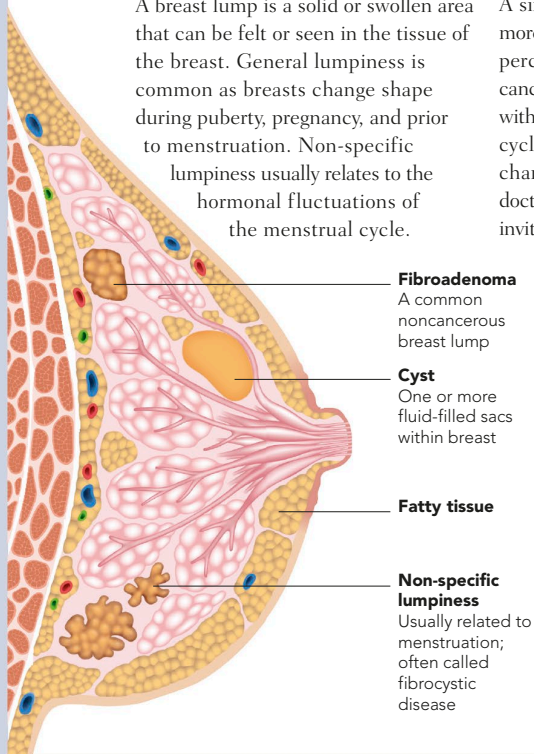
FEMALE REPRODUCTIVE DISORDERS

MANY FEMALE REPRODUCTIVE DISORDERS ARE HARMLESS, AND SOME ARE EVEN SYMPTOMLESS. HOWEVER, WIDE HORMONAL FLUCTUATIONS AND PHYSIOLOGICAL STRESSES CAN LEAD TO MORE SERIOUS DISORDERS, INCLUDING VARIOUS TYPES OF CANCER.

BREAST LUMPS

A breast lump is a solid or swollen area that can be felt or seen in the tissue of the breast. General lumpiness is common as breasts change shape during puberty, pregnancy, and prior to menstruation. Non-specific lumpiness usually relates to the hormonal fluctuations of the menstrual cycle.

A single lump may be an overgrown lobule, and a more defined one may be a cyst. Only a small percentage of lumps are a symptom of breast cancer. All women should familiarize themselves with the shape of their breasts during the menstrual cycle, so they can look and feel for abnormal changes, and immediately report them to their doctor. From the age of around 50, women are invited to attend regular screening.



BREAST CANCER

Cancer of the breast is the most common female cancer. The risk increases with age, doubling every 10 years. The causes are unclear, but risk factors have been identified. Women with higher exposure to oestrogen – for example, through having an early puberty, late menopause, or no children – have a higher risk. Age is significant, with many more cases occurring over the age of 50. Faulty genes are also a known cause. A breast lump, usually painless, is often the first sign of breast cancer.

ENDOMETRIOSIS

Endometriosis is a common condition, affecting many women of childbearing age. It can cause debilitating pain and very heavy periods; in severe cases, the condition can lead to fertility problems. The endometrium, the lining of the uterus, is shed approximately once every month as part of the menstrual cycle. Endometriosis is when small areas

of endometrial tissue grow outside the uterus, most commonly on the ovaries and in the pelvis. These pieces of tissue respond to hormonal changes and bleed during menstruation. Since the blood cannot leave the body through the vagina, its normal exit, it irritates nearby tissues, causing pain and eventually forming scars. The cause of the disorder is unknown.